

The University of Houston -- Spring 2015
Poetry: Marianne Moore & Mina Loy
English 7396, 23479 – Syllabus

Professor Gregory
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OH: T/Th 1-2pm
and by appt.

Required Texts: Mina Loy, *The Lost Lunar Baedeker (LLB)* (required)
Marianne Moore, *Complete Poems (CP)* (required)
Carolyn Burke, *Becoming Modern* (required)
Linda Leavell, *Holding on Upside Down* (required)
Robin Schulze, ed., *Becoming Marianne Moore (BMM)*
(required – available in book store & on reserve)
Critical essays assigned below

This course explores the poetry of two modernist poets, Mina Loy & Marianne Moore. Though their work differs markedly in affect and mode, Ezra Pound linked the two as practitioners of “logopoeia,” which he defined as “poetry that is akin to nothing but language, which is a dance of the intelligence among words and ideas...” Though you might argue with that characterization, both succeeded in part because they eschewed the familiar “feminine” sentimentality of the period and presented themselves as very (if not exclusively) rational. With radically innovative prosodies and revolutionary understandings of what modern women might have to say, their bodies of work turn out to be among the most challenging and engaging of the 20th century.

The course will explore the poetry written across the long careers of both poets, the history of scholarship on their work and of the availability of their texts (though both are more available now, Loy was out of print for decades, and Moore’s work was [and still is] in print only in limited form). We will also look at the role of biography in reception, and read the two most recent biographies of each (Loy [Carolyn Burke, 1996]; Moore [Linda Leavell, 2013]). In addition, the course will take advantage of the presence at UH this Spring of a major cohort of Moore critics, who will be part of the [21st-century Moore conference on campus March 19-22, 2015](#).

Online resources: <http://moore123.com>

http://www.english.illinois.edu/maps/poets/m_r/moore/moore.htm

http://www.english.illinois.edu/maps/poets/g_l/loy/loy.htm

<http://www.francisnaumann.com/Daughters%20of%20DADA/Loy.html>

The Modernist Journals Project: <http://modjourn.org/journals.html>.

21-st Century Moore Scholarship

http://www.uh.edu/class/ws/Programs/ConferencesColloquia/Marianne_Moore/

January

26

Introduction – Marianne Moore and Mina Loy

Please come to class having read as much as possible of Leavell’s Moore biography (read this one 1st) & Burke’s Loy biography (read 2nd, since most of our Loy discussion will come later).

Discussion of poems: **Moore (CP)**—“Poetry,” “Silence,” **Loy (LLB)**—“Parturition”

Modernist context; the role of institutions, biography & identity in poetic careers / reception.

NB: Additional optional pieces will be posted for reference as you have time and interest.

February

- 2 **Moore** (*BMM*): Read Schulze Introduction (1-17) and *Observations* (41-96 + Notes 137-139 + First presentations & choose 2 Publication Context Entries—383-493; check those 2 out at Modernist Journals project). Focus: “A Talisman,” “In This Age...,” “Critics & Connoisseurs,” “Roses Only,” “The Fish,” “Black Earth,” “In the Days of Prismatic Color,” “Dock Rats,” &c
Essays: Reception, *CRMM* (Thayer, Monroe, HD, Pound, Eliot &c); Holley, “Art as Exact Perception” & “Diligence, Magic,” Churchill, “MM: The Poetics of ‘Conversity’”
- 9 **NO CLASS meeting – Read ahead in Observations and re-read last week’s poems**
Essays: Miller, “Sexology, Style and the Poet’s Body,” McCabe, “Let’s Be Alone Together,” Rainey, “The Price of Modernism” (on *The Waste Land*’s publication in *The Dial*, for framework discussion of the context of modernist publication)
- 16 **Moore** (*BMM*) *Observations* (97-135” + notes [139-151) – with focus on: “England,” “New York,” “When I Buy Pictures,” “A Grave,” “Marriage,” “An Octopus,” “People’s Surroundings,” “Sojourn in the Whale,” “Picking and Choosing,” &c
Essays: Patricia Willis, “The Road to Paradise: First Notes on Marianne Moore’s ‘An Octopus’”; Fiona Green, “The magnitude of their root systems’: ‘An Octopus’”
- 23 **Moore** as Dial editor (1925-29) Jayne Marek, “The Ironic ‘Editorial We’: MM at the *Dial*,” & readings in the Dial (Sept. 1927).
Read in *CP* pp. 5-30; 95-122 – with focus on “The Steeple Jack,” “The Jerboa,” “Virginia Britannia,” “Bird-Witted,” “The Pangolin,” “Paper Nautilus”
Essays: Eliot’s Introduction to Moore’s *Selected Poems*; White, Introduction to & readings from *A-Quiver with Significance*; Slatin on Virginia Britannia; Harter on Moore’s 30s Poems
Book Report 1

March

- 2 **Moore** Read in *CP* pp. 125-174; 251-260 – with focus on “In Distrust of Merits,” “Tom Fool at Jamaica,” “In the Public Garden,” “The Arctic Ox,” “Combat Cultural,” &c
Essays: Jarrell & Miller essays on “In Distrust of Merits”; Kertzer on Poetic Argument; Levy, “No Poet Has Been So Chaste”; Green on MM & the NYkr
Book Report 2
- 9 **Moore** Read in *CP* pp. 205-247 – with focus on “Granite and Steel,” “To a Giraffe,” “Blue Bug,” “Love in America,” “Tippoo’s Tiger,” “The Camperdown Elm,” “The Magician’s Retreat”

Essays: Ashbery on Moore (*CRMM*); Vincent, "The Magician's Advance"; Gilcrest, Olson & Gregory essays on "The Camperdown Elm"

Optional: Kahan, "The Viper's Traffic-Knot"

Book Report 3

16 **SPRING BREAK – no class**

19-22 **Marianne Moore conference – UH – come if you can!**

23 Retrospect of the conference, emerging trends & on the trajectory of Moore's writing career, her publication history, and her posthumous reception.

Moore, "Those Various Scalpels"

30 **Loy**, Read in *LLB* pp. 3-50; 149-166

Essays: Churchill, "ML: The Poetics of Dislodging"

+ the role of autobio / identity-based poetic presentation

Book Report 4

April

- 6 Loy** Read in *LLB* pp. 53-105 (Songs for Joannes &c)
Essays: Linda Kinnahan, "Economics and Gender in ML, LR & MM"
Rachel Blau DuPessis, "'Seismic Orgasm': Sexual Intercourse and Narrative Meaning in Mina Loy"
Book Report 5
- 13 Loy** Anglo Mongrels and the Rose
Essays: From *Mina Loy: Woman & Poet*: Perloff, Frost and Tuma Essays on AMR;
& Rachel Potter, "Obscene Modernism and the Wondering Jew: Mina Loy's 'Anglo-Mongrels and the Rose'"
Book Report 6
- 20 Loy** *LLB* pp. 109-146
Essays:
Maera Shreiber, "Divine Women, Fallen Angels: The Late Devotional Poetry of Mina Loy"
Amy Morris, "'You Should Have Disappeared Years Ago': The Poetics of Cultural Disappearance in Mina Loy's Late Poems"
Suzanne Hobson, "Mina Loy's Conversion and the Profane Religion of Her Poetry"
- 27 Loy**, Insel, Sacred Prostitute
Essays: David Ayers, "Mina Loy's *Insel* and Its Context"
Andrew Gaedtke, "Mina Loy's *Insel* as Clinical Fantasy"

May

- 4 Moore & Loy -- LAST CLASS - closing discussion**
- 11 SEMINAR PAPER DUE**

Course requirements:

20-25pp. seminar paper, due May 11 – on Moore, Loy or both.

Weekly Blackboard posts on readings. About 500 words each - your response to the main idea(s) of at least one piece of the criticism assigned and some aspect of the primary reading—not a summary of the work. You may include questions, or point to individual poems that especially interest or puzzle you. These responses to be posted by 7:00 pm on Saturday so everyone will have time to read them by Monday's class.

Book Review. A formal book review of one of the listed books – to be circulated before class a day before due. 10 minutes discussion in class, not read aloud.

Conference Notes. TBD

Books to choose from for reviewing assignment:

[if there's something you don't see there that you'd like to review, check it out with me]

Bazin, Victoria. *MM and the Cultures of Modernity* (Ashgate, 2010).

Goody, Alex. *Modernist Articulations: A Cultural Study of Djuna Barnes, Mina Loy and Gertrude Stein* (Palgrave, 2007).

Kahan, Benjamin. *Celibacies: American Modernism and Sexual Life* (Duke UP, 2013). [has 1 chapter on Moore]

Kodat, Catherine Gunther. *Don't Act, Just Dance: The Metapolitics of Cold War Culture*. New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers UP, 2014. (Chap. 1, "Combat Cultural.")

Levy, Ellen. *Criminal Ingenuity: Moore, Cornell, Ashbery, and the Struggle Between the Arts*. New York: Oxford UP 2011.

Miller, Cristanne. *Cultures of Modernism: Marianne Moore, Mina Loy, Else Lasker-Schuler. Gender and Literary Community in New York and Berlin* (U Michigan P, 2005).

Miller, Cristanne. *Marianne Moore: Questions of Authority* (Harvard UP, 1995).

Parmer, Sandeep. *Reading Mina Loy's Autobiographies: Myth of the Modern Woman* (Historicizing Modernism) Bloomsbury Academic, 2013.

Qian, Zhaoming. *The Modernist Response to Chinese Art: Pound, Moore, Stevens* (Penn State UP, 2008).

Schulze, Robin. *The Degenerate Muse: American Nature, Modernist Poetry, and the Problem of Cultural Hygiene* (Oxford, 2013). [has 1 chapter on Moore]

Swigg, Richard. *"Quick, Said the Bird": Williams, Eliot, Moore and the Spoken Word* (U of Iowa P, 2012).

Vetter, Lara. *Modernist Writings and Religio-Scientific Discourse: H.D., Loy, and Toomer* (Palgrave, 2010).

Vincent, John Emil. *Queer Lyrics: Difficulty and Closure in Modern American Poetry* (Palgrave, 2002).

